that country. I was overwhelmed and simply blown away.

But there were mistakes. In our first match of the tournament in Mohali, we were naïve to put the Kiwis in to bat – we thought they wouldn't be able to beat the heat. Bad move. Nathan Astle, the right-handed opener and medium pacer, cost us 117 runs before he was stumped off my bowling. Chasing 286, we tried hard but eventually lost by 22 runs, failing to build on the momentum I had provided as opener (59 off 46, 4x4, 2x6).

During the next match in Gwalior, a city once ruled by Pathans, Saeed Anwar and I ran a number at the top of the order. We would help put up a solid total and offer a dynamic start – made fashionable in 1996 by the famous Sri Lankan opening duo of Sanath Jayasuriya and Romesh Kaluwitharana – against the world champions themselves. Saeed was the sane mainstay of our opening partnership (32 off 60) and I went a bit off the rails on the other end (52 off 29, 9x4, 2x6). I hadn't done much with the ball in that series till then, but was pleased to see that Saeed and I had developed a good chemistry as Pakistan's opening combination. We put up 289 on board – a massive total in those times, unlike today, when even 300-plus cannot guarantee a win. The Lankans, who had gained a reputation of being smart chasers, fell short by 30 runs.

Finally, in the heat wave of north India, Pakistan had marked their arrival in the series.

Soon it was time for our third match, against India. I'd waited for that moment for a long time.

For me, the India story begins with the six that Javed Miandad had hit off Chetan Sharma in Sharjah in 1987. That stroke not only cleared the fence and won Pakistan the match in incredible style, but also captured the imagination of millions of Pakistanis and Indians for years. It became a psychological benchmark for Pakistan. It wasn't any ordinary shot, because it made clear whenever comparisons were drawn between India and Pakistan that Pakistan was the better team. Period. Eventually, over the years, the Indians would improve – vastly – but Javed bhai's six is so memorable that even today it continues to give Pakistan some extra momentum whenever the team plays in the UAE (United Arab Emirates). Such was the impact and obsession with that match's outcome that there was even a commemorative rhyme that was taught at school, documenting that last shot.

The desert was burning
Chetan was bowling
Javed was batting
Runs required: four
This had never happened before
Chetan bowled a strange ball
It never touched the ground at all
You know what happened to that ball?
It went straight into the VIP Hall!

After that great six, Pakistan became the *badshah* of every tournament held in Sharjah and our domination against India at the same venue continued for several years. This track record built up my India obsession even more. As a young boy, I didn't have the means to travel to see any of those games. But on television I don't think I missed even a single India–Pakistan match.

But there was baggage, too. There was, of course, our defeat in the 1996 World Cup quarterfinal in Bangalore at the back of my mind. (I hadn't received a call-up for the national side